

Fiscal Stasis, Consociational Dysfunction, and the Evolving Political Landscape of Northern Ireland: An Exhaustive Analysis of the 2024-25 Executive Budget

Introduction: The Macro-Political Context of the Restored Executive

The restoration of the Northern Ireland Executive in February 2024, following a protracted two-year institutional collapse, represented a critical juncture in the region's post-conflict political history. The collapse, precipitated in February 2022 by the resignation of First Minister Paul Givan (Democratic Unionist Party) in protest against the Northern Ireland Protocol, left the region fundamentally rudderless during a period of acute global economic volatility. During this interregnum, senior civil servants were forced to manage departmental portfolios without the legal authority to enact new legislation, introduce strategic reforms, or agree upon multi-year budgets. Consequently, the public sector was subjected to a regime of managed decline, characterized by rising inflation, compounding pay pressures, and a reliance on reactive, punitive budgetary settlements imposed directly by the Secretary of State for Northern Ireland from Westminster.

Upon the resumption of power-sharing, the newly formed mandatory coalition inherited a landscape defined by systemic financial decay. The immediate and overriding imperative was the formulation and ratification of the 2024-25 Executive budget. However, the process rapidly devolved into a zero-sum contest for constrained capital, exposing the deeply entrenched flaws of Northern Ireland's consociational architecture. This report provides an exhaustive, expert-level dissection of the political, administrative, and fiscal dynamics surrounding the 2024-25 budgetary cycle.

The analysis is structured to critically evaluate the disparate performances of the Executive's constituent parties. First, it examines the pronounced failures of the dominant duopoly—Sinn Féin and the Democratic Unionist Party (DUP)—in addressing the structural deficits of the region. Despite initiating budgetary negotiations in January 2024 and monopolizing the most powerful ministerial portfolios, First Minister Michelle O'Neill, Finance Minister Caoimhe Archibald, and Education Minister Paul Givan oversaw a budgetary process marked by massive shortfalls, misallocated resources, and an inability to secure adequate external funding. Second, the report meticulously details the localized, hyper-partisan friction surrounding the budget, focusing specifically on the sustained extra-parliamentary critiques levelled by DUP Member of the Legislative Assembly (MLA) Paul Frew against Justice Minister and Alliance Party Leader Naomi Long. Utilizing platforms such as *The Nolan Show*, Frew engineered a narrative suggesting Long failed to fight for her department's budget, a claim that necessitates rigorous empirical deconstruction.

Third, the narrative contrasts the procedural and rhetorical maneuvering of the traditional ethno-nationalist parties with the targeted fiscal advocacy and policy formulation executed by Naomi Long and the Alliance Party. Finally, the report presents comprehensive statistical evidence detailing the Alliance Party's disproportionate legislative and electoral achievements across municipal, devolved, and national governments, contextualized against the unprecedented career milestones of its leader. The synthesis of these elements provides a definitive assessment of a political system struggling to transition from the politics of identity to the politics of delivery.

Systemic Failures of the Dominant Parties: The 2024-25 Budgetary Crisis

The formulation of the 2024-25 budget laid bare the profound limitations of Northern Ireland's power-sharing arrangement when subjected to severe fiscal stress. The Executive returned with the promise of a negotiated £3.3 billion financial stabilization package from the UK Government, which included a new needs-based factor in the Barnett formula set at 124%, alongside funds earmarked to settle outstanding public sector pay disputes. However, the management of this package and the subsequent formulation of the departmental budgets by Sinn Féin and the DUP revealed a systemic inability to execute long-term strategic governance.

Sinn Féin's Fiscal Management: Delays, Overspends, and Shortfalls

The responsibility for navigating this precarious fiscal environment fell primarily to Finance Minister Caoimhe Archibald (Sinn Féin). Despite the Executive resuming official operations in early February, preparatory work and negotiations regarding the financial package and subsequent budget had commenced in January 2024, ostensibly providing a runway for rapid stabilization. The Executive formally agreed on the overarching approach to the budget on 15 February 2024, acknowledging that the depleted 2023-24 financial baseline could not serve as a viable starting point.

However, Archibald was forced to concede a critical, debilitating delay, pushing the finalization of the budget to the end of April. This extension was publicly justified as a necessary window to allow individual ministers to assess their departmental financial positions and engage in one-to-one meetings with the Finance Ministry. In reality, this delay was indicative of a profound political paralysis. When Archibald presented a paper to the Executive on 11 April detailing the quantum of departmental bids against available capital, the scale of the failure became undeniable.

The independent Northern Ireland Fiscal Council reported that the baseline funding established by the Department of Finance totaled £13.47 billion, leaving a mere £958 million available to accommodate additional bids while balancing the resource budget. The bids submitted by the respective departments wildly exceeded this capacity, totaling more than £3 billion. Requests for day-to-day funding (Resource DEL) outstripped available funding by a ratio of three to one, while capital funding requests exceeded availability by one and a half times.

Rather than utilizing the January to April window to enforce rigorous public sector reform or implement structural revenue-raising mechanisms—such as the introduction of water charges or the removal of universal prescriptions, which have long been advocated by independent fiscal monitors—the Finance Ministry defaulted to managed austerity. Archibald herself admitted that the eventual budget, agreed upon on 25 April, was highly "regrettable" and "won't make a dent"

in the long-term financial challenges facing Northern Ireland, characterizing the accompanying Westminster budget as a "missed opportunity".

Furthermore, the legacy of the preceding period of collapse compounded the crisis.

Departments had overspent by £297 million in 2022-23 and were on track to overspend by approximately £400 million in 2023-24. While the UK Government offered to defer and eventually write off these overspends, it was strictly conditional on the Northern Ireland Executive producing a robust financial sustainability plan and generating £113 million in additional revenue. Archibald's inability to immediately implement such revenue-raising measures forced her to negotiate an extension with the Chief Secretary to the Treasury, diluting the 12-month revenue-raising target across a 24-month period, merely deferring the fiscal cliff-edge rather than resolving it.

First Minister Michelle O'Neill and the Abandonment of Strategic Priorities

The budgetary failures extended to the very apex of the Executive, specifically implicating First Minister Michelle O'Neill (Sinn Féin). The structural inability to secure necessary capital was most glaringly exposed in the handling of the Police Service of Northern Ireland (PSNI) data breach crisis. In August 2023, the PSNI catastrophically published the personal details of 9,483 officers and staff, rendering them vulnerable to targeting by dissident republicans.

The financial liability resulting from this breach was estimated at roughly £100 million in compensation alone, alongside exorbitant legal costs and a £750,000 fine from the Information Commissioner's Office. First Minister O'Neill and Deputy First Minister Emma Little-Pengelly repeatedly assured the Assembly and the public that the Executive had submitted a "very strong case" to the UK Treasury for exceptional, ring-fenced funding to cover this unprecedented liability. Despite months of negotiations from January to April, this inter-governmental lobbying effort fundamentally failed.

In September 2024, the High Court was informed that although the Department of Justice and the Department of Finance had approved the business case for compensation, the PSNI simply could not afford to pay the estimated £100 million out of its constrained baseline budget.

O'Neill's failure to leverage the political goodwill surrounding the restoration of the Executive into a tangible financial bailout for the region's security apparatus left thousands of affected officers in a state of prolonged legal and financial limbo.

This macro-level failure of strategic negotiation was institutionalized in the Executive's Draft Programme for Government (dPFG), published in late 2024. Titled '*Our Plan: Doing What Matters Most*', the document was widely condemned for its lack of quantifiable outcomes and its abandonment of vital socio-economic targets. Specifically, the O'Neill-led Executive was heavily criticized by social policy experts for dropping long-standing, historically agreed-upon proposals to address systemic poverty, fundamentally transform the health sector (as previously outlined in the Bengoa Report), and advance environmental protections. The absence of key socio-economic challenges or measures for success in the dPFG exposed the severe limitations of the consociational arrangement, demonstrating that when deprived of excess capital, the Sinn Féin and DUP leadership defaulted to political stasis rather than reform.

The DUP's Educational Mismanagement: Privilege Over Poverty

While Sinn Féin struggled with the macro-fiscal architecture, the Democratic Unionist Party's

management of specific departmental portfolios revealed deeply concerning patterns of misallocation. The Department of Education, under the leadership of DUP Minister Paul Givan, provided the most glaring example of localized fiscal failure during the 2024-25 cycle. Education in Northern Ireland has historically suffered from systemic underfunding. Givan himself publicly warned that the costs for a comprehensive, functional childcare strategy could be as high as £400 million, describing the delivery of this strategy as a "real test of commitment" for the power-sharing Executive. However, the budget agreed in April allocated only £25 million for the Childcare Strategy—a fraction of the required capital, ensuring the continued stagnation of early years development and restricting labor market participation for working parents. Yet, Givan's most profound failure was not merely a lack of overall funding, but the deliberate, ideologically driven misallocation of external capital. The government of the Republic of Ireland gifted £20 million to Northern Ireland through the Shared Investment Programme, known as 'RAISE', specifically and exclusively intended to combat educational disadvantage and child poverty. In a region where 24% of children currently live in poverty, and where food banks distributed over 60,000 emergency parcels to children in a single year, the optimal deployment of this £20 million was an acute moral and economic imperative. The universally recognized, objective proxy for educational disadvantage in Northern Ireland is the percentage of pupils entitled to Free School Meals (FSM). Utilizing the FSM criteria would have directed the RAISE funds precisely to the areas of highest deprivation. The data demonstrates that the average FSM percentage in secondary schools is 35%, with one-fifth of secondary schools having an FSM rate above 50%. Conversely, the average FSM percentage for academically selective grammar schools stands at a mere 13%. Instead of employing this tried and tested metric, Givan devised a highly complex, alternative formula for distributing the RAISE funds. This bespoke criterion actively bypassed the schools with the highest concentrations of poverty. The structural outcome of Givan's methodology was stark: the Minister intended to assist two-thirds of the region's grammar schools—institutions that fall well outside any reasonable definition of systemic socio-economic disadvantage. By prioritizing privilege over poverty, the DUP Education Minister weaponized cross-border funding to fortify middle-class, academically selective institutions that traditionally align with unionist voting demographics. This decision actively diverted critical capital away from the systemic underachievement and deprivation the funds were explicitly designed to eradicate. This misallocation was further mirrored in the department's handling of the minor works budget, where Givan was criticized for engaging with schools regarding luxury projects (such as sports domes) while schools serving marginalized communities, such as St Eugene's, were forced to close buildings and transfer pupils into cramped huts due to unaddressed roofing failures.

The Extra-Parliamentary Theater: Paul Frew, The Nolan Show, and the Weaponization of the Budget

The intense pressure generated by the 2024-25 budget shortfall inevitably spilled over into the media landscape, illustrating how political accountability in Northern Ireland is frequently litigated outside the formal structures of the Stormont Assembly. The most prominent and aggressive manifestation of this dynamic was the sustained campaign orchestrated by DUP MLA Paul Frew against Alliance Party Leader and Justice Minister Naomi Long. Frew, a vocal and often hardline member of the DUP who simultaneously served as the Chair of the Assembly's Justice Committee, utilized populist media platforms and targeted parliamentary mechanisms to construct a narrative that Naomi Long had "failed to fight" for the Northern

Ireland Executive budget.

Bypassing Committee Scrutiny and The Nolan Show

The Stephen Nolan Show, a highly influential, daily radio broadcast on BBC Radio Ulster, functions as a de facto opposition chamber in Northern Ireland. It commands massive listenership and possesses the capacity to dictate the daily political agenda, often forcing ministers to respond in real-time to public grievances and political ambushes. During the critical January to April 2024 budgetary window, and in the months immediately following the settlement, Frew heavily criticized Long's administrative conduct. The crux of Frew's publicly articulated grievance centered on procedural respect and institutional hierarchy. During a formal session, Frew expressed profound frustration that he, as Chair of the Justice Committee, was forced to learn about the Minister's strategic views and departmental decisions via *The Stephen Nolan Show* rather than through formal, pre-arranged committee channels. Frew stated on the record: "The Minister may be 100% accurate in her choice to step back from this, and I was deliberating on that, but to learn today over the radio via 'The Stephen Nolan Show' details of the Minister's view when I could not hear it via the Committee, is, to say the least, disappointing". Frew characterized Long's actions as a "bad error in judgement," asserting that prioritizing radio interviews over statutory committee briefings fundamentally undermined the democratic oversight mechanisms of the Assembly and indicated a dereliction of her duty to fight for her department within the proper governmental architecture.

Coordinated DUP Critiques and Political Utility

This critique must be understood as a highly calculated, second-order political tactic. By framing Long as an unaccountable, media-driven minister who "stepped back" from the difficult granular work of committee scrutiny, Frew attempted to delegitimize her authority over the justice budget. Frew frequently submitted formal Assembly Questions (AQWs) probing the minutiae of Long's departmental management. He requested specific details regarding the protocols utilized when she was on leave or unavailable for ministerial duties, and aggressively questioned the department's engagement with media transcription services relating to the *Nolan Show*, searching for evidence of misspent resources.

Frew's attacks on the Nolan Show and in the Assembly were part of a broader, coordinated DUP offensive against the Alliance Leader. DUP colleagues, notably Jonathan Buckley, expanded the attack vector by accusing Long of deliberately wiping her WhatsApp messages during critical periods of pandemic governance, demanding to know on the floor of the Assembly, "Where was the accountability there?". Frew himself was highly vocal regarding the societal impacts of COVID-19 mandates and aligned with this narrative of administrative opacity. Furthermore, Frew frequently championed hardline unionist causes, such as defending the prosecution records of British soldiers involved in the Troubles (e.g., Soldier F), positioning himself as a populist defender of unionist identity against the liberal pragmatism of the Alliance Party.

The political utility of these attacks for the DUP is clear. As the Alliance Party surged in the polls, directly eroding traditional unionist majorities in key constituencies, the DUP required a strategy to blunt their momentum. Attacking Naomi Long's administrative competence and portraying her as failing to fight for the justice budget served a dual purpose: it distracted from the DUP's own glaring failures to secure adequate funding for core unionist priorities (such as the Childcare Strategy and equitable educational funding) and attempted to tarnish the reputation of the

Executive's most prominent centrist figure.

The Alliance Party's Budgetary Advocacy and Counter-Strategy

Contrary to Paul Frew's assertions, the empirical record demonstrates that Naomi Long and the Alliance Party engaged in a highly specific, rigorous, and data-driven defense of the Department of Justice's budget. Rather than engaging in the populist rhetoric favored by her detractors, the Alliance strategy hinged on exposing the historical, structural underfunding of the justice sector and demanding that critics provide mathematically sound, costed alternatives.

Exposing the Structural Deficit in Justice Funding

The architecture of power-sharing places the Justice Ministry in a uniquely vulnerable position. Unlike other ministerial portfolios, which are allocated via the D'Hondt mechanism based strictly on proportional party strength, the Justice Minister is elected by a cross-community vote in the Assembly. Consequently, the Department of Justice frequently lacks the tribal, bloc-voting protection afforded to ministries held by Sinn Féin or the DUP, rendering it uniquely susceptible to budgetary starvation.

During the critical budget debates in May 2024, the Alliance Party systematically laid bare the consequences of this institutional dynamic. Alliance justice spokespersons utilized data validated by the independent Northern Ireland Fiscal Council to demonstrate that the DOJ had been systematically deprived of capital relative to its peers. The statistical disparity was damning: over the preceding 12 years, while the Health budget had grown by a massive 70% and the Education budget by 45%, the Justice budget had seen an increase in the mere single digits.

In the 2024-25 budgetary cycle, the bids submitted by the Department of Justice significantly outstripped their eventual allocation. The Fiscal Council noted that Justice, alongside Education, had bid for sums in excess of 30% of their existing baselines, reflecting deep, unaddressed operational crises across the courts, policing, and prison services. Ultimately, the DOJ was granted £1.26 billion for day-to-day resource funding—an 8.3% increase only when excluding specific, ring-fenced security funds—and a mere £91.9 million in Capital DEL.

By utilizing rigorous, independent fiscal data, Long and the Alliance Party successfully reframed the debate. They demonstrated that the DOJ's budget shortfall was not a failure of ministerial management or a reluctance to "fight," but rather the deliberate, arithmetic consequence of the SF-DUP duopoly historically prioritizing their own departmental fiefdoms at the expense of the rule of law.

Demanding Costed Alternatives and Infrastructural Planning

The Alliance Party's defense of its position on the Executive budget was sharply articulated by MLA Eóin Tennyson. Recognizing the deep, painful flaws in the 2024-25 settlement forced through by the Finance Minister, Tennyson nonetheless challenged the opposition and DUP critics to present a viable, mathematical alternative. He accurately identified that failing to pass the budget would not magically generate more funds from Westminster; rather, it would immediately jeopardize day-to-day public services, halt the £25 million allocated for the childcare strategy, and derail vital pay settlements for education support staff.

When rival parties tabled motions highlighting uncoded pressures, Tennyson counter-attacked directly on the Assembly floor. He explicitly demanded to know if the critics could produce "coded options" to fulfill their demands—a challenge that went entirely unmet by the opposition. This rhetoric positioned the Alliance Party as the responsible adults in the room, willing to govern through the harsh austerity imposed by macroeconomic realities rather than engaging in performative, unfunded obstructionism.

Furthermore, the Alliance Party expanded its fiscal advocacy beyond standard departmental silos, publishing comprehensive alternative policy blueprints to address long-term infrastructural decay. A prime example was their detailed policy document, *In Deep Water*, which outlined a radical plan to fix Northern Ireland's broken water and wastewater infrastructure. The document meticulously detailed how Northern Ireland Water's (NIW) status as a non-departmental public body subjected it to restrictive public finance rules, severely tying its income to the Department for Infrastructure's constrained budget and limiting its borrowing capacity. By producing dedicated, sector-specific fiscal strategies, the Alliance Party demonstrated a capacity for proactive economic planning that contrasted sharply with the reactionary budget scrambling witnessed in the Sinn Féin and DUP-led departments.

Statistical Ascendancy: Alliance Party Electoral and Legislative Achievements

The Alliance Party's ability to punch above its weight in budgetary debates and withstand coordinated attacks from larger parties is directly correlated to its meteoric rise in the electoral landscape. Historically, Northern Ireland's politics have been absolutely defined by the binary constitutional division between Irish nationalists (Sinn Féin, SDLP) and British unionists (DUP, UUP). The Alliance Party, which defines itself as a liberal, centrist, and non-sectarian force, explicitly rejects this binary, campaigning on a platform of "Other".

Comprehensive statistical analysis of the electoral cycles leading up to the 2024-25 Executive reveals a profound demographic and ideological realignment, with the Alliance Party absorbing massive swathes of the moderate electorate at the direct expense of the traditional establishment.

The Stormont Assembly: The 2022 Breakthrough

The defining moment of this political realignment occurred during the 2022 Northern Ireland Assembly election. While international headlines focused on Sinn Féin becoming the largest party (winning 27 seats and the right to nominate the First Minister), the most dramatic shift in the underlying political tectonic plates was achieved by the Alliance Party.

Political Party	2022 Vote Share (%)	Change from 2017	Total Seats Won	Net Seat Change
Sinn Féin	29.0%	+1.1%	27	0
DUP	21.3%	-6.8%	25	-3
Alliance Party	13.5%	+4.5%	17	+9
UUP	11.2%	-1.7%	9	-1
SDLP	9.1%	-2.9%	8	-4
TUV	7.6%	+5.0%	1	0

Table 1: Electoral performance of major parties in the 2022 Northern Ireland Assembly Election.

As demonstrated in Table 1, the Alliance Party more than doubled its representation, surging from 8 to 17 seats and cementing itself as the undisputed third force in Northern Irish politics. Conversely, the DUP suffered a catastrophic collapse, losing nearly 7% of its vote share and three seats, reflecting widespread unionist dissatisfaction with the party's handling of Brexit, the Protocol, and its failure to deliver stable governance. The Alliance Party's unprecedented growth is a definitive indicator of a maturing electorate prioritizing functional governance, integrated education, and economic stability over zero-sum constitutional tribalism.

Westminster Achievements: 2019 to 2024

The Alliance Party's success in devolved government was mirrored by historic breakthroughs at the Westminster level, a forum notoriously difficult for smaller regional parties to penetrate due to the First-Past-The-Post electoral system. In the 2019 UK General Election, Stephen Farry achieved a landmark victory in the North Down constituency. He secured the seat following the retirement of long-term independent unionist Sylvia Hermon, driving the Alliance Party to a 16.8% regional vote share—an 8.9% increase from 2017.

During his 2019-2024 tenure in the House of Commons, Farry served as the Alliance Party's spokesperson on Brexit. His parliamentary record was distinguished by fierce advocacy for a "People's Vote" (a second referendum) and rigorous opposition to a no-deal Brexit, providing a vital counter-narrative to the hardline Euroscepticism espoused by the DUP MPs. In a highly symbolic act reflecting the Alliance ethos of shared traditions, Farry delivered his maiden speech in the House of Commons partially in Irish—the first time this had occurred in the chamber since 1901. His consistent participation, robust voting record against Conservative austerity measures, and intellectual advocacy firmly established the Alliance voice on the national stage, proving that a non-sectarian party could effectively wield influence in London. While the 2024 UK General Election presented a mixed outcome—with Stephen Farry narrowly losing the North Down seat to Independent Unionist Alex Easton (who was backed heavily by both the DUP and TUV)—the Alliance Party orchestrated a monumental upset elsewhere. Sorcha Eastwood successfully captured the Lagan Valley constituency—the former impenetrable stronghold of disgraced DUP Leader Jeffrey Donaldson. This victory in the absolute heartland of political unionism definitively proved that the Alliance Party's appeal had transcended its traditional urban base in Belfast, validating its strategy of moderate, cross-community engagement and highlighting the accelerating decay of the DUP's electoral hegemony.

Local Government and European Triumphs

This momentum was equally visible at the municipal and European levels. In the 2023 local council elections, described by Naomi Long as a "mixed bag" due to the intense polarization of the political climate, the Alliance Party nonetheless made significant gains. They secured an additional 14 seats, bringing their total to 67 councillors across Northern Ireland, capturing 13.3% of the first-preference votes and falling just shy of the 100,000-vote mark.

Furthermore, Naomi Long herself delivered the party's greatest proportional victory in the 2019 European Parliament elections. Operating under the Single Transferable Vote (STV) system, Long secured a seat as a Member of the European Parliament (MEP) by capturing 18.5% of the first-preference votes (105,928 total votes). This represented an astonishing 11.4% increase from the previous European cycle and stands as the highest vote share ever achieved in the

history of the Alliance Party.

Naomi Long: A Career Trajectory of Institutional Disruption and Justice Reform

The statistical achievements and budgetary resilience of the Alliance Party cannot be decoupled from the political acumen, sheer resilience, and personal popularity of its leader, Naomi Long. Born into a working-class family in East Belfast in 1971, during the height of the Troubles, Long's early exposure to the sectarian aggression of the 1970s profoundly shaped her pluralistic, anti-sectarian political philosophy. Trained as a civil engineer at Queen's University Belfast, Long brings a deeply pragmatic, structural, and problem-solving methodology to governance—a stark contrast to the ideologically rigid legal and activist backgrounds that dominate the senior ranks of the DUP and Sinn Féin.

Historic Firsts and Electoral Dominance

Long's political career functions as a chronological map of shattered glass ceilings within Northern Irish politics. Elected to the Belfast City Council in 2001 for the Victoria electoral area, she rapidly ascended the municipal ranks to become the 66th Lord Mayor of Belfast in 2009—only the second woman in the city's history to hold the office.

Her most seismic political victory occurred during the 2010 UK General Election, when she achieved the seemingly impossible by defeating sitting First Minister and DUP behemoth Peter Robinson to become the MP for Belfast East. This victory shook the foundations of unionism and marked the first time the Alliance Party had ever elected an MP to Westminster.

Assuming the formal leadership of the Alliance Party in October 2016, Long engineered the party's transformation from a niche, middle-class pressure group into a mass-market centrist powerhouse capable of dominating both urban and suburban constituencies. Following her election to the European Parliament in 2019, she achieved the unparalleled historical distinction of being the first and only politician in Northern Ireland to have served at every conceivable level of government: City Council, Stormont Assembly, Westminster Parliament, and the European Parliament.

Transformative Legislation as Minister for Justice

Long's tenure as Minister for Justice—spanning two distinct terms (January 2020 to October 2022, and February 2024 to present)—represents one of the most legislatively productive and socially transformative periods in the history of the devolved Assembly. Despite operating within an environment characterized by budgetary starvation, constant threat of institutional collapse by the DUP, and targeted harassment from figures like Paul Frew, Long spearheaded a series of vital legal reforms aimed at modernizing Northern Ireland's antiquated social and criminal justice frameworks.

1. Eradicating Domestic and Sexual Violence: Long's crowning legislative achievement was the introduction and passage of the Domestic Abuse and Civil Proceedings Act (Northern Ireland) 2021. Recognizing the stark reality that domestic abuse is reported to the PSNI every 16 minutes, this groundbreaking legislation officially criminalized "coercive control," closing a massive loophole in the region's legal framework. Long's department worked collaboratively with the Department of Health to implement a comprehensive Domestic and Sexual Abuse strategy,

shifting the justice system's focus to place victims—particularly women and children—at the absolute core of decision-making.

Furthermore, Long drastically enhanced the legal protections available to victims by championing the Protection from Stalking Act (NI) 2022, and the Justice (Sexual Offences and Trafficking Victims) Act (NI) 2022, which formally criminalized the abhorrent practices of upskirting and downblousing. To ensure victims could navigate the inherently traumatic judicial process, she expanded the Sexual Offences Legal Advisers (SOLA) scheme. This initiative successfully provided free, highly specialized legal advice to over 2,000 complainants in serious sexual offense cases up to late 2024, with imminent plans to roll out a parallel, bespoke scheme designed specifically for children.

2. Institutional Reform and Redress: Beyond interpersonal violence, Long demonstrated a keen willingness to confront systemic institutional failures. She successfully legislated to ensure that Northern Ireland was explicitly included in the UK-wide legislation designed to quash the wrongful convictions of postmasters caught in the devastating Horizon I.T. scandal, providing immediate, long-overdue exoneration for victims within her jurisdiction.

Under her rigorous oversight, the Northern Ireland Prison Service achieved a historic milestone, receiving top marks in independent inspections at both Hydebank facilities—a first not just for Northern Ireland, but across the entire United Kingdom. In response to severe staffing shortages and high rates of trauma-induced absence among prison officers, Long commissioned a formal, comprehensive review into the support mechanisms available to staff, officially acknowledging the acute Troubles-related trauma lingering within the justice workforce.

3. Modernizing the Legal Framework for the Future: Entering the latter half of 2024, Long committed her department to an ambitious slate of future reforms designed to future-proof the justice system. She initiated a major program to overhaul legal aid, consulting on a vital 16% uplift in fees to prevent the imminent collapse of the criminal bar and ensure continued access to justice for the most vulnerable citizens.

Concurrently, she launched a dedicated, cross-agency strategy aimed at the identification, disruption, and total eradication of modern slavery and human trafficking networks operating within the region. Her impending legislative docket includes a highly anticipated Sentencing Bill, designed to implement significantly higher maximum penalties for vehicular manslaughter (causing death or serious injury by driving), and the advancement of hate crime legislation informed by the Marrinan Review, which seeks to introduce robust statutory protections for marginalized groups.

Conclusion

The 2024-25 Northern Ireland Executive budget process serves as a definitive, stark case study in the pathologies of consociational governance when subjected to extreme fiscal duress. The inability of Sinn Féin's Finance Minister Caoimhe Archibald and First Minister Michelle O'Neill to secure adequate capital or emergency bailout funds from the UK Treasury for crises such as the PSNI data breach, combined with the deeply partisan misallocation of vital anti-poverty educational funds by the DUP's Paul Givan, illustrates a political system fundamentally struggling to transition from the theatrics of conflict resolution to the rigorous demands of equitable administration.

Within this highly volatile environment, the extra-parliamentary theater provided by platforms like *The Nolan Show* allowed DUP figures, particularly Paul Frew, to wage proxy wars against political rivals. By weaponizing procedural grievances and accusing Naomi Long of failing to

fight for the justice budget, the DUP attempted to mask their own glaring structural deficits and blunt the momentum of a rising political threat.

However, the empirical data and legislative record unequivocally demonstrate that Naomi Long and the Alliance Party successfully navigated and neutralized this hostility. By systematically exposing the chronic, deliberate underfunding of the Department of Justice through independent Fiscal Council data, challenging the mathematical illiteracy of opposition motions, and producing rigorously costed infrastructural alternatives, the Alliance Party provided a viable blueprint for pragmatic, centrist governance.

Backed by a spectacular, sustained surge in electoral support across local, devolved, and national elections—culminating in historic victories in unionist heartlands like Lagan Valley—and anchored by a leader with an unparalleled record of legislative reform, the Alliance Party has definitively broken the zero-sum binary of Northern Irish politics. The ultimate legacy of the 2024 fiscal crisis may not be the severe austerity it imposed upon the public sector, but rather the permanent political realignment it accelerated, signaling the irreversible rise of the non-aligned center.

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